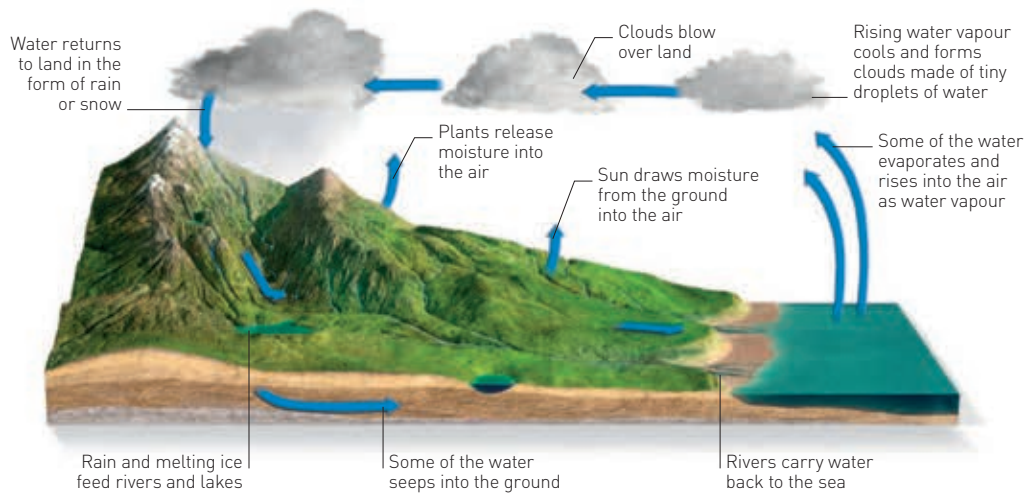


WATER CYCLE

Powered by the Sun's heat, the water cycle circulates between sea, air, and land. The Sun-warmed surface water is constantly evaporating (turning into water vapour). The rising vapour cools and condenses, forming clouds that may be carried over land. Here, it falls back as rain or snow, and flows over the land before the water finds its way back to the sea.



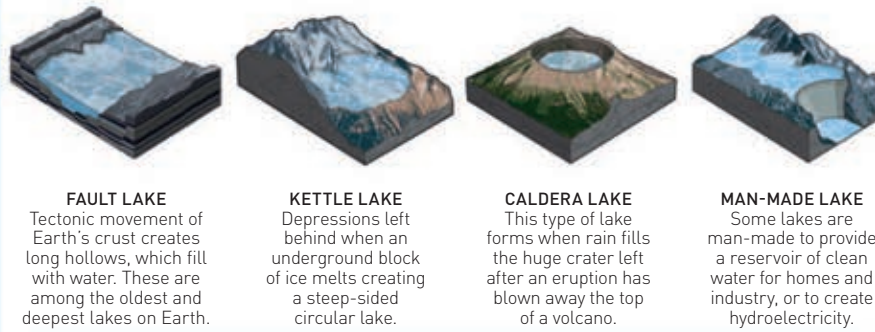
LARGEST LAKES

Some lakes are just shallow pools that eventually dry out, while others are so vast that they are like inland seas.

- 1 CASPIAN SEA**
Area: 371,000 sq km (143,000 sq miles) This lake was once part of the Mediterranean Sea; it was cut off when sea levels fell during the last ice age.
- 2 SUPERIOR**
Area: 82,414 sq km (31,820 sq miles) One of the five Great Lakes of North America, and the largest freshwater lake in the world.
- 3 VICTORIA**
Area: 69,485 sq km (26,828 sq miles) The waters of Lake Victoria in Africa fill a shallow basin in the centre of a plateau.
- 4 HURON**
Area: 59,600 sq km (23,000 sq miles) This is the second largest of the North American Great Lakes.
- 5 MICHIGAN**
Area: 58,000 (22,000 sq miles) Also one of the five Great Lakes but located entirely within the USA.

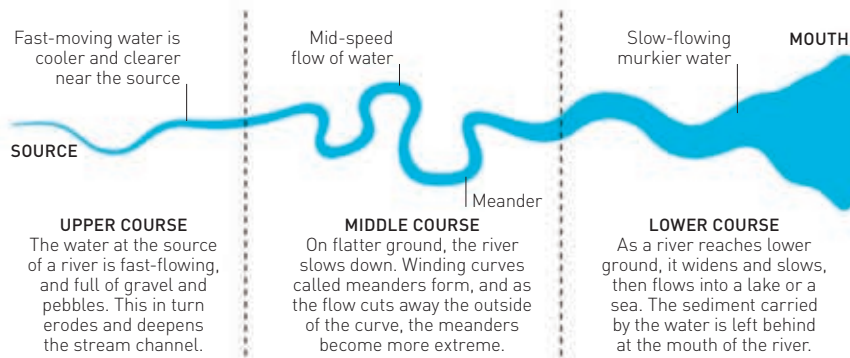
LAKE TYPES

Lakes form in various ways, depending on how the hollow on Earth's surface was created, and most contain fresh water. They are found in a number of environments, including mountains, deserts, and plains. Some lakes are millions of years old but most are much younger.



RIVERS

Most rivers begin life as small, fast-flowing streams that join up to form bigger, slower ones. They start life in higher ground, where rainwater or melting snow collects and trickles downhill. Some rivers also form when lakes overflow or from springs.



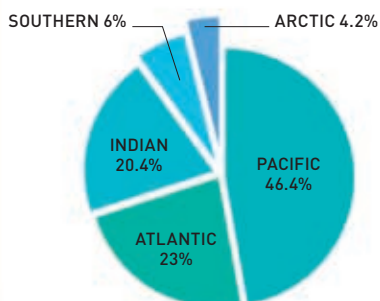
LONGEST RIVERS

Earth has some incredibly long rivers that snake across its surface. These are the five longest rivers of the world.

- 1 NILE**
Length: 6,670 km (4,145 miles) Africa's River Nile has two major tributaries (branches): the Blue Nile and the White Nile.
- 2 AMAZON**
Length: 6,450 km (4,005 miles) More water flows through South America's mighty Amazon than any other river.
- 3 YANGTZE**
Length: 6,378 km (3,964 miles) China's Yangtze River is the world's deepest river as well as the third-longest river.
- 4 MISSISSIPPI-MISSOURI**
Length: 5,970 km (3,710 miles) The Mississippi and Missouri rivers combine to form North America's longest river system.
- 5 YENISEI**
Length: 5,539 sq km (3,445 sq miles) The Yenisei River starts in Mongolia and flows through Russia.

OCEAN SIZES

This chart shows the total area covered by each ocean. The Pacific is the deepest and by far the largest ocean, covering almost half the Earth. The Arctic is the smallest, coldest, and shallowest ocean.



WATER POWER

Earth's essential resource can move with considerable force, and modern techniques have been developed to harness this incredible power into energy.



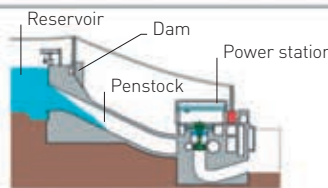
HYDROELECTRIC
Hydroelectric dams are built to convert a river's kinetic energy (energy of movement) into electrical power.



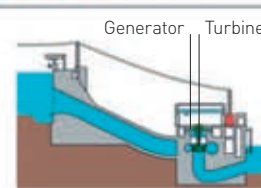
TIDAL SURGE
Tidal barrages work in a similar way to hydroelectric dams, generating power from rising and falling tides.

HYDROELECTRIC ENERGY

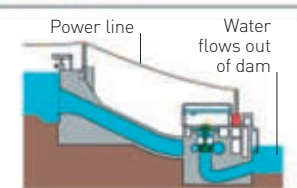
Hydroelectric power stations use the force of moving water to produce electrical energy. The amount of energy created is determined by the flow of water.



- 1 WATER IS RELEASED**
Water is stored in a reservoir and released into giant tubes (penstocks) inside the dam.



- 2 WATER PRESSURE**
The force of the water spins the blades of the turbines, which are connected to electricity generators.



- 3 ELECTRICITY IS PRODUCED**
Power lines carry away electricity, while the water flows off downstream, away from the dam.